to abolish the barbarous law by which any one who changes from the Christian or any other religion to the Mahomedan and then back again is considered worthy of death. The whole body of the priesthood (Ulema) of Turkey are against granting the demands of the Ambassadors but the latter it is said threaten to break off all friendly relations with the Porte if their demands are not complied with.[68] The Persians even add that a steamer was at Constantinople ready to take them away if they did not receive a favorable answer on a certain day, but as the Persians are anxious to see the Turks heads broken no matter by whom, this last piece of news is not to be depended upon.

Mr Bonham wanted to establish a post between this and Erzeroom. There is already one between that and Constantinople and from thence all over the world, but the thing did not go on. He wanted Col Sheil now our Chargé d'affaires at Tehran, to allow him the sum which he (the Col.) gets from the Govt for sending couriers once a month and Mr B. engaged to despatch his post once a week. But the Col would not agree. It would have been no great benefit to me personally, for had the post been established we should all have had to pay for our letters and as it is we receive them gratis by the Govt couriers. The Greek merchants established here have foot posts once a week who come from Erzeroom when the roads are not blocked up with snow in ten or twelve days. The distance is about 370 miles. This is not bad walking when you consider that they carry large bundles of letters and newspapers. These Greek merchants are with one or two exceptions a most outlandish set, the Persians are a much more intelligent set of men than they are, that is the gentry. Yet these fellows call themselves Europeans and have the insolence to call the Persians barbarians; in Europe also the Persians are called barbarous I think without justice. A people who have Euclid and Algebra surely can not be called barbarous and these the Persians have. Not having learnt them from the Europeans but from the Arabs. You perhaps may not be aware that this last science is of Arabic origin and still with us bears the same name *ul jebr*.[69] The last word "jebr" or "gebr" meaning cruelty oppression injustice "ul" the article and it received this name from the "cruelty" or the "injustice" of making a poor fellow split his brain with learning a thing so difficult. But to return to the Greeks, of whom there are some ten or fifteen in Tabreez now, except about their trade they have not two ideas in their heads. All day long they are employed at their warehouses either transacting

[68] The Porte did bow to the demands of the European ambassadors and the law was abolished, a fact which did not prevent similar massacres right up until World War I.

[69] *al jabr* is literally "setting a bone" i.e., "reducing it from a fractured state," cf. E. W. Lane, Arabic-English Lexicon, London, 1865, Bk. I, pt. 2, p. 373–74. Applied to computation *al jabr* means "the resolution (i.e., addition, subtraction, etc.) of fractions and whole numbers," hence *algebra*, which came into the western languages in this form through Late Latin.

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